

A N
A C C O U N T
O F A
V O Y A G E
U P T H E

River de la Plata,

And thence over Land to

P E R U.

With Observations on the Inhabitants, as well *Indians* and *Spaniards*; the Cities, Commerce, Fertility, and Riches of that Part of *America*.

By *Monf. Acarete du Biscay.*

L O N D O N:
Printed for *Samuel Buckley*, at the *Dolphin*
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Fleetstreet. 1698.



A MAP
of the Provinces
PARAGUAY
and
TUCUMAN
with
the River Plate
London Printed for S. Buckley

English Miles

48 96 192 288 384 448

A Description of Buenos Ayres.

BEfore I say any thing of my Journey to *Pern*, I will set down what I observ'd remarkable at *Buenos Ayres* whilst I tarry'd there. The Air is pretty temperate, much as 'tis in *Andalouſia*, but not quite ſo warm, the Rains fall almoſt as often in Summer as Winter; and the Rain in ſultry weather uſually breeds divers kinds of Toads, which are very common in this Country, but are not venomous. The Town ſtands upon a riſing Ground, on the ſide of the River *de la Plata*, a Muſquet ſhot from the Channel, in an Angle of Land made
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by a little Rivulet, call'd *Riochuelo*, which falls into the River a quarter of a League from the Town; it contains 400 Houses, has no enclosure, neither Wall nor Ditch, and nothing to defend it but a little Fort of Earth surrounded with a Ditch, which commands the River, and has Ten Iron Guns, the biggest of which is a Twelve Pounder; there the Governor resides who has but 150 Men in Garrison, which are form'd into Three Companies Commanded by Three Captains, whom he appoints at will, and indeed he changes them so often, that there is hardly a Wealthy Citizen but has been a Captain; these Companies are not always full, because the Souldiers are drawn by the cheapness of Living in those Parts to desert frequently, notwithstanding they endeavour to keep them in the Service by a large pay, which is *per diem* Four Reals, worth 1 s. 6 d. *English*, and a Loaf of 3 d. *ob.* which is as much as one Man can eat. But the Governor keeps 1200 tame Horses in a Plain thereabouts for his ordinary Service, and in case of necessity to mount the Inhabitants of the Place, and form a small Body of Cavalry. Besides this Fort, there is a little Bastion at the

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Mouth

Mouth of the Rivulet wherein they keep Guard, there are but Two Iron-Guns mounted upon it, each carrying a Three Pound Ball ; this commands the place where the Barks come ashore to deliver or take in goods, which are liable to be visited by the Officers of the Bastion when they lade and unlade. The Houses of the Town are built of Earth, because there is but little Stone in all those Parts up as far as Peru ; they are thatch'd with Canes and Straw, have no Stories, all the Rooms are of a Floor, and are very Spacious ; they have great Court-yards, and behind their Houses large Gardens full of Orange-trees, Lemon-trees, Fig-trees, Apple-trees, Pear-trees, and other Fruit-trees, with store of Herbs, Cabbages, Onions, Garlick, Lettice, Peas, Beans, and especially their Melons are excellent, the Soil being very fat and good ; they live very commodiously, and except Wine, which is something dear ; they have plenty of all sorts of Victuals, as Beef, Veal, Mutton, Venison, Hares, Coneys, Pullets, Ducks, Wild-geese, Partridges, Pidgeons, Turtles, and all kind of Wild-fowl ; and so cheap, that one may buy Partridges for a Penny a piece,

pièce, and the rest proportionably. There are likewise abundance of Ostriches who herd in Flocks like Cattle, and tho' they are good Meat, yet none but the Savages eat of them. They make Umbrellas of their Feathers, which are very commodious in the Sun; their Eggs are good, and every body eats of 'em, tho' they say they are of hard Digestion. I saw one thing of these Creatures very remarkable, and that is, while the Hen sits upon the Eggs, they have the Instinct or Foresight to provide for their Young; so five or six days before they come out of the Shell, they set an Egg in each of the four Corners of the place where they sit, these Eggs they break, and when they rot, Worms and Maggots breed in 'em in prodigious numbers, which serve to nourish the Young Ostriches from the time they are hatch'd till they are able to go farther for their sustenance. The Houses of the better sort of Inhabitants are adorn'd with Hangings, Pictures, and other Ornaments and decent Moveables, and all that are tollerably well to pass are serv'd in Plate, and have a great many Servants, *Blacks, Moulatos, Mestices, Indians, Cabres, or Sambos*, who are all Slaves. The *Negroes* come

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from

from *Guinea*; the *Moulatos* are begotten by a *Spaniard* upon a *Black*; the *Mestices* are born of a *Spaniard* and an *Indian*, and the *Sambos* of an *Indian* Man and a *Mestice*, all distinguishable by their Colour and Hair. They employ these Slaves in their Houses, or to cultivate their Grounds, for they have large Farms stock'd with Grain in abundance, as Wheat, Barley and Millet, or to look after their Horses and Mules, who feed upon nothing but Grass all the Year round, or to kill Wild-Bulls, or in fine to do any kind of Service. All the Wealth of these Inhabitants consists in Cattle, which multiply so prodigiously in this Province, that the Plains are quite cover'd with 'em, particularly with Bulls, Cows, Sheep, Horses, Mares, Mules, Asses, Swine, Deer, and others, insomuch that were it not for a vast number of Dogs, who devour the Calves and other young Beasts, they would over-run the Country, they make so great profit of the Skins and Hides of these Animals, that a single Instance will be sufficient to shew how far it might be improv'd by good hands: The 22 *Dutch* Ships that we found at *Buenos Ayres* were each of them laden with 13 or 14000 Bull-hides

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at least, which amount to above 300000 *Livers*, or 33500 *l. Sterling*, bought by the *Dutch* at Seven or Eight *Reals* a piece, that is under an *English* Crown, and sold again in *Europe* for Twenty-five Shillings *English* at least. When I express'd my astonishment at the sight of such an infinite number of Cattle, they told me of a Stratagem sometimes made use of, when they apprehend a descent from any Enemies, that is matter of greater wonder, and 'tis this; they drive such a Herd of Bulls, Cows, Horses and other Animals to the Shore-side, that 'tis utterly impossible for any number of Men, even tho' they should not dread the fury of those Wild Creatures, to make their way through so great a drove of Beasts. The First Inhabitants of this place, put every one their mark upon those they could catch, and turn'd 'em into their enclosures, but they multiply'd so fast, that they were forc'd to let 'em loose, and now they go and kill them according as they want 'em, or have occasion to make up a quantity of Hides for Sale. At present they mark only those Horses and Mules which they catch to tame and breed up for Service. Some Persons make a great Trade of sending

them to *Peru*, where they yield 50 *Pata-gons*, or 11 *l.* 13 *s.* 4 *d.* *Sterling* a pair. Most of the Dealers in Cattle are very Rich, but of all the Trading People the most considerable are they that Traf-fick in *European* Commodities. Ma-ny of whom are reputed worth 2 or 300000 Crowns, or 67000 *l.* *Sterling*. So that a Merchant worth no more than 15 or 20000 Crowns is look'd upon as a mean Retailer; of these last there are near 200 Families in the Town, that make 500 Men bearing Arms, besides their Slaves who are three times that Number, but are not to be reckon'd of any Defence, because they are not al-low'd to bear Arms: Thus the *Spaniards*, *Portuguese*, and their Sons (of whom those that are born upon the place are term'd *Criolos*, to distinguish them from the Natives of *Spain*) and some *Mestices* are the Militia, which with the Souldiers in Garrison, compose a Body of above 600 Men, as I computed them in several Musters, for they draw out on Horse-back Three times a Year near the Town on Festival Days. I observ'd there were many Old Men among them that did not carry Fire-arms, but only a Sword by their side, a Lance in hand, and a Buck-ler

ler at their shoulder: They are also most of them Marry'd and Masters of Families, and consequently have no great stomach to Fighting. They love their Ease and Pleasure, and are entirely devoted to *Venus*; I confess they are in some measure excusable in this point, for most of their Women are extreamly pretty, well shaped, and clear skin'd; and withal so faithful to their Husbands, that no Temptations can prevail with them to loosen the Sacred Knot: But then if their Husbands transgress, they are often punish'd with Poison or Dagger. The Women are more in Number than the Men. Besides *Spaniards*, there are a few *French*, *Hollanders*, and *Genouese*, but all go for *Spaniards*, otherwise there would be no dwelling for them there, especially those that differ in their Religion from the *Roman-Catholicks*, because the Inquisition is settled there.

The Bishop's Revenue amounts to 3000 *Patagons*, or 700 *l. Sterling per Annum*. His Diocess takes in this Town and *Santa Fe*, with the Farms belonging to both; Eight or Ten Priests Officiate in the Cathedral, which is built of Earth as well as the Houses. The *Jesuits* have a College; the *Dominicans*, the *Recol-*

leñs, and the *Religious de la Mercy*, have each a Convent. There is likewise an Hospital, but there are so few poor People in these Parts that 'tis of little use.

Situate upon the River *de la Plata*, large Vessels might come up to it, were it not for a great bank that obstructs the passage a little above *Buenos Ayres*. Nevertheless 'tis a very advantageous Post, because 'tis the only passage from *Peru*, *Chili* and *Tucuman* to *Paraguay*, and in a manner the Magazine of the Commodities